

U.S. Tax Court

Electronic Filing - Case Management System

Case Form Usability Study
February 2019

Test Participants

- Recruited: 5
- Gender: Female
- Age: 31 - 64
- Computer Use: More than once weekly
- Other Criteria: Filed income tax returns within 5 years

Summary of Key Findings

Are the form instructions clear?

No, while users read the instructions and thought they made sense, they often had to re-read them or return to them while filling out the form

Summary of Key Findings

Is the form information presented logically?

Yes, users had no issues with the order of form information or how it was presented

Summary of Key Findings

Do users understand what fields are required and how to enter the information?

Yes, users understood field formatting and successfully entered in appropriate data, but they often missed the “all fields required” text

Summary of Key Findings

Do users understand the difference between a small tax case and a regular tax case?

Yes, language for small/regular tax cases was clear, but the design could be improved for emphasis and clarity

Summary of Key Findings

Do users understand how to select a trial location and what their options are?

Yes, users understood trial location options, but some would change the type of case to get a trial location closer to them

Summary of Key Findings

What type of error messaging do users expect?

Users expected more specific field-level error messaging, in addition to the page-level messages that were shown

Are form instructions clear?

Findings

- ? The field-level reminder message for the petition upload is helpful
- ? Users needed to refer back to instructions while completing the form
- ? Instructions for what is needed to begin filing a petition and how to prepare to file are not adequate for most users
- ? Some users didn't fully understand instructions for combining the Notice and Petition form into one PDF - specifically confusion about whether the petition form we say to complete first IS the online form they are filling out now
- ? All users were surprised that there was a filing fee, since it's not mentioned until after the petition is filed

Are form instructions clear?

Recommendations

- ✓ Improve the details and placement of the form instructions to prepare users for completing the form itself (update in progress)
- ? Include information regarding fee payment before the petition is submitted (planned for MVP)

Is the form order presented logically?

Findings

- ? The overall organization of the form fields is logical to users
- ? Location of the petition upload field could be more clearly tied to the form instructions

Recommendations

- ✓ Move the upload petition field closer to the form instructions (update in progress)

Do you users understand what fields are required and how to enter information?

Findings

- ? “All fields required” message was easily missed
- ? Users didn’t skip any fields
- ? Users could successfully enter all information in correct format

Recommendations

- ✓ Update the placement of the “All Fields Required” message (update in progress)

Do users understand the difference between a small vs. regular tax case?

Findings

- ? Overall information on case procedure types was clear
- ? Right to appeal was an important factor in selecting a case procedure
- ? Users understood the < and > symbols, but would prefer text
- 😞 Participants thought that the blue header text in the accordion section were links and tried to click them
- 😞 Accordion design is lost between the other information

Do users understand the difference between a small vs. regular tax case?

Recommendations

- ? Replace greater than (>) and less than (<) symbols with text (MVP)
- ? Reinforce the “no right to appeal” for small tax case selection (MVP)
- ? Change the color of the header text in the accordion so they aren’t confused with links (MVP)
- ? Update the design of the accordion to be more prominent (MVP)

Do users understand how to select a trial location and what their options are?

Findings

- ? Select Trial Location field label is clear
- ? All users were able to select a location
- ? Users understood that the trial location options were dependent on the case procedure type
- ? Some users would consider changing their case type to go to a closer trial location
- ? Some users mentioned they were unsure if they should select the location closest to them

Do users understand how to select a trial location and what their options are?

Recommendations

- ? Update language to prompt users to select their closest city (MVP)

What type of error messaging do users expect?

Findings

- ? Users understood that their form had errors
- ? The color and design was what they expected
- ? Users expected to see where the errors happened along with information at both the page level and field level

What type of error messaging do users expect?

Recommendations

- ✓ Provide a more detailed page-level list of which fields have errors (update in progress)
- ✓ Add field-level error design and messaging (update in progress)

Other Findings

Findings

- ? Users expected to see instructions on how to file a petition on the dashboard
- ? “Start a Case” button remaining prominent on dashboard after case is submitted was confusing to some users
- ? Participants didn’t always notice the upload success indicator for the petition PDF
- ? Participants did not fully understand that they would not be able to edit their form information after they submitted it, despite reading the warning above the “Submit” button

Other Findings

Findings

- ? Search box was confusing to users, unsure of what they would be able to search for
- ? Users were generally confused about why they had to complete the petition form as a PDF and had to combine the petition and notice into a single PDF

Other Findings

Recommendations

- ? Update the success indicator for file upload fields (MVP)
- ? Build out instructions and other contextual information on the petitioner dashboard (MVP)
- ? Remove the search box for petitioners (MVP- HOLD)
- ? Make it more clear that users can't edit the petition after they submit the case (MVP)
- ☒ Build out the entire petition Form 2 into the case form and eliminate the combined PDF (post- MVP)

Questions?